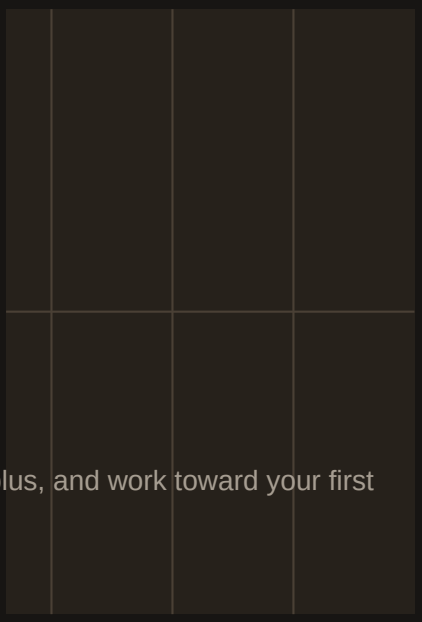
YOUR WEALTHY UNCLE

THE FIRST $10K SYSTEM

A 90-DAY MONEY RESET

A practical system to take control of your money, build a sustainable surplus, and work toward your first $10,000.



$0

START WHERE YOU ARE

SAVE • ORGANIZE • BUILD

WELCOME FROM YOUR WEALTHY UNCLE

You do not need another lecture about coffee, avocado toast, or becoming a millionaire before Friday.

You need a system you can use on an ordinary Tuesday when the bills are real, the paycheck is finite, and life keeps happening.

This workbook is built around a simple principle: **financial progress becomes easier to see when your money has jobs before you spend it.**

We will start with the numbers you actually have. Then we will build a workable spending plan, create a cash buffer, organize debt, address the behaviors that quietly erase raises, and build a measurable path toward $10,000.

The 90-day target is to install the system. The $10K is the destination. For some people it will take longer than 90 days; for others, circumstances may move faster. The plan should fit reality.

WALTER'S RULE

Clarity first. Control second. Growth third.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Do not read this like a novel. Use it like an operating manual.

Each section follows the same cycle: **understand** → **see it** → **do it** → **track it** → **repeat it.**

Keep your recent bank statements, bills, debt balances, and recurring income information nearby. The first pass is about accuracy, not aesthetics.

When you reach a worksheet, stop reading and complete it. The blank page is not the product; the decision you make on it is.

- **Week 1:** make the numbers visible.
- **Weeks 2–4:** remove leaks and stabilize cash flow.
- **Days 31–60:** build the surplus and automate the basics.
- **Days 61–90:** measure, adjust, and set the next target.

CONTENTS

	SECTION	WHAT YOU'LL DO
00	**The $10K Reality Check**	Goal math, sustainable surplus, realistic timelines
01	**Know Your Money**	Financial snapshot and baseline
02	**Where Your Money Actually Goes**	30-day spending map
03	**The Money Leak Audit**	Recurring leaks and cleanup
04	**Build a Realistic Budget**	Budget methods and monthly plan
05	**Find Your Essential Spending Floor**	Minimum practical cost of living
06	**The Payday System**	A repeatable payday sequence
07	**Build an Emergency Buffer**	Progressive cash resilience
08	**Debt Without the Shame**	Inventory, snowball and avalanche
09	**Credit Cards Without Getting Trapped**	Statements, minimums and repayment
10	**Lifestyle Inflation**	The raise trap
11	**Impulse Spending**	The 24-hour pause
12	**Spending Triggers**	Better defaults
13	**Your Savings Rate**	Measure the trend
14	**Build Your $10K Roadmap**	Milestones and routes
15	**Increase Your Surplus**	30-day surplus challenge
16	**The 90-Day Reset**	Days 1–7, 8–30, 31–60, 61–90
17	**Automate Your Money**	Protect the decisions
18	**The Weekly Money Check**	15-minute review
19	**The Monthly Money Reset**	30–45 minute ritual
20	**What Happens After $10K?**	Turn a milestone into a foundation
A	**The Toolkit**	Reusable trackers and checklists
B	**The 90-Day Final Review**	Compare Day 1 with Day 90

A NOTE BEFORE WE START

This is an educational money-management workbook, not individualized financial advice. Your income, expenses, debts, family responsibilities, taxes, banking system, and local rules can change what is appropriate for you.

The system intentionally avoids individual investment recommendations. It focuses on budgeting, saving, debt organization, cash reserves, financial behavior, and measurable routines.

When the book gives example numbers, they are examples—not promises or universal targets.

WALTER'S RULE

Never sacrifice essential needs or required debt obligations just to hit a savings number.

00

THE $10K REALITY CHECK

Separate the destination from the timeline. A 90-day system can be installed even when the destination takes longer.

THE GOAL

Turn the $10K goal from a motivational phrase into simple planning math.

THE SURPLUS MATH

$250	$500	$1K
monthly surplus	monthly surplus	monthly surplus

If you can consistently create a $100 monthly surplus, $10,000 would require roughly 100 months through saving alone. At $250, roughly 40 months. At $500, roughly 20 months. At $750, roughly 14 months. At $1,000, roughly 10 months.

These are simple calculations, not forecasts. Your actual path changes with income, spending, debt, unexpected expenses, and consistency.

The point is to stop asking, *“How do I save $10K fast?”* and start asking, *“What sustainable surplus can I create and protect?”*

WALTER'S RULE

Choose the timeline from your sustainable surplus, not from an impressive-looking chart.

THE $10K ROUTES

There is more than one way to reach the same destination. A person with a low surplus may need a longer runway. Someone with variable income may have uneven months. Someone carrying expensive debt may need to split the plan between stability and payoff.

Your route can combine three levers: reducing unnecessary outflow, increasing income, and improving the organization of money so less is lost to timing and forgetfulness.

- **Route A — Stabilize:** close a negative monthly gap.
- **Route B — Build:** create a repeatable positive surplus.
- **Route C — Accelerate:** increase income and/or reduce costs while protecting the surplus.
- **Route D — Protect:** build cash resilience so one surprise does not erase months of progress.

YOUR $10K STARTING POINT

Write the numbers you will use throughout this book.

Current savings	Starting balance	
Monthly take-home	Reliable monthly income	
Monthly outflow	Average total spending	
Monthly surplus	Income minus outflow	
Total debt	Current balances	

First milestone	The next number you want to reach	

01

KNOW YOUR MONEY

You cannot improve a system you cannot see. The first job is to build a clean snapshot.

THE GOAL

Know exactly what comes in, what goes out, what you owe, and what you currently have.

THE FINANCIAL SNAPSHOT

IN	OUT	DEBT	SAVE
income	spending	obligations	progress

Use take-home income rather than headline salary. Include recurring income you can reasonably count on and separate irregular income.

Then list essential expenses, discretionary spending, debt obligations, and current savings. If a number is unknown, estimate it and return to your statements.

The most important output is your **monthly surplus**: take-home income minus total monthly outflow. If it is negative, stabilization comes before aggressive saving.

WALTER'S RULE

Your first win is not saving money. Your first win is knowing the truth about your money.

YOUR FINANCIAL SNAPSHOT

Use actual recent numbers.

Monthly take-home income	After tax and deductions	
Current cash savings	Accessible money	
Essential monthly expenses	Minimum practical cost of living	
Debt minimums	Required payments	
Discretionary spending	Flexible spending	
Monthly surplus	Income minus total outflow	
Next milestone	First amount you want to reach	

READ THE SNAPSHOT

A positive surplus means you have an engine to work with. The next job is deciding where that surplus goes before it disappears.

A near-zero surplus means timing, leaks, or lifestyle pressure may be consuming most of your income.

A negative surplus means the current system spends more than it earns. The first objective is to close the gap through a combination of expense changes, income changes, payment adjustments, or a mix.

None of these numbers is a verdict on you. They are inputs.

WALTER'S RULE

Numbers are information, not identity.

02

WHERE YOUR MONEY ACTUALLY GOES

A budget built from memory is usually a budget built from fiction. Build yours from evidence.

THE GOAL

Map the last 30 days so your plan starts with reality.

THE 30-DAY SPENDING MAP

Review the last 30 days of transactions. Use a small set of categories: housing, utilities, food, transportation, debt, subscriptions, health, personal, entertainment, shopping, and other.

Separate fixed bills from variable spending. Fixed bills are predictable. Variable spending can move significantly from month to month.

Do not start by asking what you should cut. First ask what is actually happening.

30-DAY EXPENSE MAP

Record actual totals or realistic monthly averages.

Housing	Rent / mortgage / fees	
Utilities & phone	Power, water, internet, phone	
Food	Groceries + eating out	
Transportation	Fuel, transit, parking, rides	
Debt	Minimums + planned extra	
Subscriptions	Apps, streaming, memberships	
Personal / shopping	Clothes, hobbies, care	
Entertainment	Events, leisure	
Other	Everything else	

THE VALUE TEST

A category is not automatically bad because it is optional. The useful question is whether the amount you spend is producing enough value for you.

A small recurring expense that you never use may be more valuable to remove than a larger occasional expense that you genuinely planned for.

Look for repetition. Repetition is where small decisions become annual totals.

WALTER'S RULE

Do not optimize pennies while ignoring recurring hundreds.

03

THE MONEY LEAK AUDIT

Most leaks are not dramatic. They are small, repeated, convenient, and invisible.

THE GOAL

Find recurring outflows that do not deserve to survive another month.

FIVE TYPES OF LEAKS

Unused: you pay for something you barely use.

Convenience: you repeatedly pay more because the cheaper option takes more effort.

Duplicate: two services or purchases solve the same problem.

Trigger-based: spending appears after stress, boredom, social pressure, or celebration.

Forgotten: a renewal or recurring charge continues because you stopped noticing it.

MONEY LEAK AUDIT

List the leak, the frequency, and the decision you will make.

Leak #1	Cost / frequency / keep-reduce-cancel	
Leak #2	Cost / frequency / keep-reduce-cancel	
Leak #3	Cost / frequency / keep-reduce-cancel	
Leak #4	Cost / frequency / keep-reduce-cancel	
Leak #5	Cost / frequency / keep-reduce-cancel	
Leak #6	Cost / frequency / keep-reduce-cancel	

THE 15-MINUTE LEAK CLEANUP

Do these in one sitting.

- [ ] Cancel one unused subscription.
- [ ] Turn off one unnecessary renewal.
- [ ] Remove one saved payment method from a high-spending app.
- [ ] Replace one recurring convenience purchase with a cheaper default.
- [ ] Set a 24-hour pause for non-essential purchases above your chosen threshold.
- [ ] Move the first month of estimated savings into your goal.

04

BUILD A REALISTIC BUDGET

A budget is not a punishment. It is a plan for what your income is supposed to do.

THE GOAL

Choose a budgeting method that fits your actual cash flow.

THREE METHODS

Category budget: each category receives a spending ceiling.

Zero-based budget: expected income is assigned to jobs until nothing is unassigned.

Paycheck budget: each paycheck is planned against the obligations that arrive before the next paycheck.

There is no universal winner. Choose the method you can maintain and understand.

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	USEFUL WHEN
Category	Set a ceiling for each category.	You like clear spending caps.
Zero-based	Assign expected income to jobs.	You want maximum control.
Paycheck	Plan around payment timing.	Cash-flow timing is the main problem.

YOUR MONTHLY BUDGET

Make every dollar—or every unit of income—accounted for.

Expected take-home	Income you expect	
Essential spending	Minimum practical cost	
Debt minimums	Required payments	
Savings target	Chosen sustainable amount	
Flexible spending	Planned discretionary amount	
Buffer	Room for timing surprises	

IRREGULAR EXPENSES BELONG IN THE PLAN

Car maintenance, annual subscriptions, gifts, repairs, school costs, travel, and other non-monthly expenses can wreck a budget when they are treated as surprises.

Create a list of known irregular expenses and estimate their annual cost. Divide the annual amount by 12 to understand the monthly planning burden.

You do not need a perfect estimate. You need a visible one.

WALTER'S RULE

A predictable expense is not an emergency just because it happens infrequently.

05

FIND YOUR ESSENTIAL SPENDING FLOOR

Your essential floor tells you what life costs before extras.

THE GOAL

Know the minimum practical cost of keeping your household functioning.

WHAT BELONGS IN THE FLOOR?

Think in terms of expenses you would protect during a financial shock: housing, basic utilities, basic food, necessary transportation, required care or insurance, and minimum debt obligations.

The definition is personal. A commuter may need transportation. A remote worker may not. A parent may have childcare that is essential to employment.

The floor is useful because it tells you what must be protected first.

ESSENTIAL SPENDING FLOOR

List only expenses you would protect in a financial emergency.

Housing	Minimum housing cost	
Utilities / communication	Necessary utilities	
Food	Basic groceries / meals	
Transportation	Necessary commuting	
Health / care	Necessary recurring care	
Debt minimums	Required minimums	
Other essentials	Necessary household obligations	

NORMAL VS. ESSENTIAL

NORMAL	ESSENTIAL	GAP
monthly cost	monthly floor	flexible layer

Write down your normal monthly spending and your essential floor. The difference is your flexible lifestyle layer.

Flexible does not mean bad. It means adjustable. Knowing the difference gives you options when income or expenses change.

06

THE PAYDAY SYSTEM

The day you get paid should trigger a sequence—not a shopping spree.

THE GOAL

Give your income jobs before your lifestyle absorbs it.

THE PAYDAY ORDER

1. **Receive.** Confirm the actual amount available.
2. **Protect.** Cover essential bills and required payments.
3. **Transfer.** Move the planned savings amount.
4. **Allocate.** Set the amount available for flexible spending.
5. **Buffer.** Leave room for timing surprises when possible.

WALTER'S RULE

Save by design, not by hoping there is money left at the end.

PAYDAY PLAN

Complete this before or on every payday.

Income received	Amount actually available	
Bills before next payday	Critical obligations	
Savings transfer	Planned transfer	
Debt extra	Beyond minimums, if applicable	
Spending allowance	Flexible spending	
Operating buffer	Unassigned cash for timing	

THE PAYDAY FAILURE TEST

If you repeatedly transfer money to savings and then move it back because essentials cannot be covered, the system is giving you feedback.

Lower the transfer temporarily, fix the cash-flow timing, or increase the surplus. A useful system should reduce financial stress, not create a cycle of false progress.

WALTER'S RULE

The right savings target is one you can protect.

07

BUILD AN EMERGENCY BUFFER

Cash reserves create breathing room. Build them progressively instead of waiting for a perfect number.

THE GOAL

Create layers of resilience that match your circumstances.

THREE STAGES

01	02	03
starter	one month	larger reserve

Stage 1 — Starter buffer: a small accessible cushion for common surprises.

Stage 2 — One month of essentials: a useful milestone for people who can reach it.

Stage 3 — Larger reserve: a target based on income stability, household responsibilities, and personal risk.

These are planning stages, not universal prescriptions.

EMERGENCY BUFFER PLAN

Choose the next milestone rather than chasing a perfect number.

Starter buffer target	First cash cushion	
Essential monthly floor	From Chapter 5	
One-month target	Essential monthly cost	
Current emergency savings	Accessible reserve	

Next milestone	Next amount to reach
Review date	When you will reassess

PROTECT THE PURPOSE

Emergency money exists to reduce the chance that a surprise forces you into expensive debt or a destructive financial decision.

Keep it accessible enough for genuine emergencies and separated enough from everyday spending that it is not treated as ordinary cash.

The right account or product depends on your country and circumstances. Compare access, fees, safety, and applicable protections.

08

DEBT WITHOUT THE SHAME

Debt is a set of numbers and obligations. You need a plan, not self-punishment.

THE GOAL

Turn a vague problem into a sequence of decisions.

BUILD THE INVENTORY

For every debt, record the lender, balance, interest rate if known, minimum payment, due date, and current status.

Then choose a payoff order while continuing required payments on every account.

Snowball: prioritize the smallest balance first.

Avalanche: prioritize the highest interest rate first.

The approaches use different priorities. Your job is to understand the trade-off and choose deliberately.

DEBT INVENTORY

One line per debt.

Debt #1	Balance / rate / minimum / due date
Debt #2	Balance / rate / minimum / due date
Debt #3	Balance / rate / minimum / due date
Debt #4	Balance / rate / minimum / due date
Debt #5	Balance / rate / minimum / due date
Debt #6	Balance / rate / minimum / due date

APPROACH	PRIORITY	WHAT IT OPTIMIZES
Snowball	Smallest balance	Visible account wins / fewer open balances
Avalanche	Highest interest rate	Interest-cost priority

YOUR PAYOFF ORDER

Write the exact order you intend to follow.

Method	Snowball or avalanche

Target #1	First account	
Target #2	Second account	
Target #3	Third account	
Target #4	Fourth account	
Extra-money rule	How windfalls / reductions will be handled	

09

CREDIT CARDS WITHOUT GETTING TRAPPED

A credit card is a payment tool. The danger appears when the repayment plan becomes unclear.

THE GOAL

Know the statement, the minimum, the due date, and the cost of carrying a balance.

THE FOUR NUMBERS

Statement balance: what the statement says you owe for that cycle.

Minimum payment: the required amount to keep the account current under the issuer's terms.

Due date: when the required payment is due.

Interest terms: the cost of carrying balances under the card agreement.

Terms vary by issuer and country. Read your actual statement.

WALTER'S RULE

Available credit is not income.

CREDIT CARD CHECK

Review every card you use.

- [ ] I know my statement closing date.
- [ ] I know my payment due date.
- [ ] I know the minimum payment.
- [ ] I know whether I am carrying a balance.
- [ ] I know the applicable interest terms.
- [ ] I have a repayment plan for current purchases.
- [ ] I do not count available credit as income.

10

LIFESTYLE INFLATION

More income can improve your life—or simply create a more expensive version of the same financial stress.

THE GOAL

Give new income a job before your lifestyle gives it one.

THE RAISE TRAP

Imagine take-home income rises from $3,000 to $3,500. The extra $500 is not automatically spending money. It is an opportunity to change your financial position.

The trap is subtle: a better phone, more delivery, another subscription, a nicer car, more nights out. Each decision can look reasonable by itself.

Six months later, you can earn more than ever and still feel like there is nothing left.

The solution is not to reject every upgrade. It is to decide deliberately.

WALTER'S RULE

Give every raise a job before you give it a lifestyle.

YOUR RAISE RULE

Write your personal rule before the next increase arrives.

Expected increase	Amount or percentage	
Savings allocation	Amount or percentage	
Debt allocation	Amount toward payoff	
Lifestyle allocation	Intentional upgrade	
Rule	One sentence you will follow	
Review date	When you will check the result	

11

IMPULSE SPENDING

The goal is not to eliminate spontaneity. It is to stop automatic decisions from becoming recurring problems.

THE GOAL

Create a pause between wanting and buying.

THE 24-HOUR PAUSE

Choose a purchase threshold that fits your income. For non-essential purchases above it, create a pause.

During the pause, ask: Do I still want it? Is it in the plan? What problem does it solve? Would I buy it tomorrow? What else could this money do?

The pause does not forbid the purchase. It makes the decision conscious.

WALTER'S RULE

If the purchase still makes sense tomorrow, you can decide tomorrow.

YOUR IMPULSE TRIGGER MAP

Map the pattern, not just the purchase.

Trigger	When does spending happen?	
Feeling	What are you feeling before it?	
Default action	What do you usually buy?	

New response	What will you do for 10 minutes instead?	
Threshold	At what amount will you pause?	
Reminder	Where will you place the reminder?	

12

SPENDING TRIGGERS

Social pressure, stress, boredom, convenience, and celebration can all change behavior.

THE GOAL

Design defaults so good decisions require less effort.

DESIGN A BETTER DEFAULT

Remove saved cards from high-spending apps. Turn off promotional notifications. Set a weekly discretionary amount before the weekend. Create a shopping list before non-essential shopping.

Build convenient low-cost alternatives for recurring expensive habits. The best default is the one you can actually follow when tired.

WALTER'S RULE

Make the desired behavior easier and the undesired behavior slightly harder.

YOUR DEFAULTS

Choose five changes for this week.

- [ ] Remove one saved payment method.
- [ ] Set one weekly discretionary spending limit.
- [ ] Create a shopping list before non-essential shopping.
- [ ] Turn off one promotional notification.
- [ ] Choose one low-cost social activity you genuinely enjoy.
- [ ] Create one convenient alternative to an expensive recurring purchase.
- [ ] Put your next savings milestone where you will see it before spending.

13

YOUR SAVINGS RATE

A savings rate is a measurement, not a moral score.

THE GOAL

Measure the trend so you can tell whether the system is changing.

THE FORMULA

10%	$340	$3.4K
example rate	saved	take-home

Savings rate = amount saved ÷ take-home income.

Example: $340 saved from $3,400 take-home income = 10%.

Do not force a universal target onto your situation. Start with a rate you can repeat. Increase it when the surplus grows.

WALTER'S RULE

A smaller target you repeat beats a bigger target you abandon.

SIX-MONTH SAVINGS RATE TRACKER

Record income, savings, and the resulting rate.

Month 1	Income / saved / rate	
Month 2	Income / saved / rate	
Month 3	Income / saved / rate	
Month 4	Income / saved / rate	
Month 5	Income / saved / rate	
Month 6	Income / saved / rate	

14

BUILD YOUR $10K ROADMAP

Turn the destination into milestones that can survive an ordinary month.

THE GOAL

Give the goal intermediate numbers so progress becomes visible.

MILESTONES

A $10,000 goal can feel abstract. Use checkpoints such as $500, $1,000, $2,500, $5,000, $7,500, and $10,000—or create milestones that fit your starting point.

Each milestone should answer three questions: **How much? By when? What behavior creates it?**

If debt or emergency savings needs attention first, some milestones can be shared between stability and the long-term goal.

$10K ROADMAP

Create a route you can explain in one minute.

Starting balance	Current savings	
Milestone 1	Amount + target date	
Milestone 2	Amount + target date	
Milestone 3	Amount + target date	
Milestone 4	Amount + target date	
$10K target	Target date if realistic	

THE THREE LEVERS

Spend less: reduce outflow without destroying the parts of life you value.

Earn more: increase income through work, skills, selling, or other legitimate means.

Organize better: prevent timing problems, forgotten bills, and automatic leaks from consuming the surplus.

You do not need one dramatic breakthrough. Multiple small levers can compound.

WALTER'S RULE

Build the surplus from several small levers instead of waiting for one dramatic breakthrough.

15

INCREASE YOUR SURPLUS

Your savings capacity is not fixed. Test both sides of the equation.

THE GOAL

Run a 30-day experiment and measure the result.

THE 30-DAY SURPLUS CHALLENGE

Choose one expense-side experiment and one income-side experiment.

Expense examples: cancel unused subscriptions, change a recurring default, set a weekly discretionary cap, reduce one high-frequency convenience expense.

Income examples: sell unused items, offer a skill-based service, take appropriate extra work, or test a small freelance offer.

The objective is not to build a fantasy business in a month. It is to prove that your monthly surplus can move.

WALTER'S RULE

Measure the experiment, not the fantasy.

30-DAY SURPLUS CHALLENGE

Make the experiments measurable.

Expense experiment	What will you change?	
Expected impact	Monthly amount freed	
Income experiment	What will you test?	
Expected impact	Monthly amount created	
Combined surplus target	New monthly target	
Review date	When you will evaluate	

WEEKLY SURPLUS ACTIONS

Repeat for four weeks.

- [ ] Review one recurring expense.
- [ ] Review one variable category.
- [ ] Complete one income-producing action.
- [ ] Transfer the savings created by the experiment.

- Record what worked and what did not.
- Do not add a recurring expense just because income increased.

16

THE 90-DAY RESET

The next 90 days are about installing the system, not performing financial theater.

THE GOAL

Move from clarity to control to building to acceleration.

DAYS 1–7 — CLARITY

Complete the financial snapshot. Map the last 30 days. List every debt. Audit subscriptions. Calculate the essential floor. Choose your budget method.

Do not chase a huge savings target yet. Your job is to make the system visible.

WALTER'S RULE

Do not optimize what you have not measured.

DAYS 8–30 — CONTROL

Run the payday routine. Remove obvious leaks. Establish the starter buffer target. Choose your debt payoff order. Implement your spending-trigger rules.

The goal is fewer uncontrolled money decisions and a positive or improving monthly surplus.

DAYS 31–60 — BUILD

Automate what makes sense. Increase the savings transfer if the first month was sustainable. Run the surplus challenge. Build the next milestone.

Use weekly reviews to adjust the plan instead of abandoning it.

DAYS 61–90 — ACCELERATE

Review your savings rate. Compare current spending with the starting snapshot. Increase the surplus where possible. Set the next 90-day target.

At day 90, the best outcome is not a perfect spreadsheet. It is a system you can continue without this workbook.

YOUR 90-DAY TARGET

Set realistic numbers you can measure.

Starting savings	Current balance	
90-day savings target	Target amount	
Monthly surplus target	Target surplus	
Debt target	Balance reduction	
Behavior target	One habit to automate	
Review date	Day 90 evaluation	

17

AUTOMATE YOUR MONEY

Automation is useful when it protects a decision you have already made.

THE GOAL

Automate the boring parts without removing your oversight.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

Depending on your bank and cash flow, consider automating recurring bills, a regular savings transfer, and debt payments you know you can cover.

Automation does not remove the need for review. Check balances, upcoming obligations, and transfers regularly.

Leave enough operating cash to prevent overdrafts or failed payments.

AUTOMATION SETUP

Choose only what fits your cash flow.

- [ ] Recurring essential bills are organized.
- [ ] Savings transfer is scheduled.
- [ ] Debt minimum payments are protected.
- [ ] I know when each transfer occurs.
- [ ] I keep enough operating cash for timing differences.
- [ ] I review automated transactions during the weekly check.

18

THE WEEKLY MONEY CHECK

Fifteen minutes once a week can prevent small problems from becoming end-of-month surprises.

THE GOAL

Create a short review that keeps the system alive.

15-MINUTE WEEKLY CHECK

Do this once every seven days.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Check your savings transfer.
- [ ] Check debt balances if you are in payoff mode.
- [ ] Identify one category that is running high.
- [ ] Make one adjustment for the coming week.
- [ ] Update your $10K progress.

WEEKLY CHECK-IN

Keep answers short and practical.

What went well?	One thing to repeat	
What surprised me?	Unexpected spending or income	

Where did I overspend?	Category + amount	
What will I change?	One concrete adjustment	
Savings this week	Amount	
Next week's priority	One action	

19

THE MONTHLY MONEY RESET

Once a month, close the old month and give the next month a job.

THE GOAL

Turn your budget into a feedback loop.

THE 30–45 MINUTE RITUAL

Review income received, total spending, savings, debt payments, subscriptions, and next month's known obligations.

Compare actual spending with the budget. Do not punish yourself for variance; explain it.

Then move money according to your priorities and choose one change for next month.

WALTER'S RULE

Your budget becomes more accurate because it learns from reality.

MONTHLY RESET

Complete at the end or beginning of each month.

- [ ] Record total take-home income.
- [ ] Record total spending.
- [ ] Record total saved.
- [ ] Calculate savings rate.
- [ ] Update debt balances.
- [ ] Review subscriptions.
- [ ] Review upcoming irregular expenses.
- [ ] Choose next month's savings target.
- [ ] Choose one expense or income experiment.
- [ ] Update $10K progress.

MONTHLY REVIEW

Close the month with decisions, not guilt.

Biggest win	What improved?	
Biggest leak	What cost more than expected?	
Savings	Amount saved	
Debt	Amount reduced	
Next priority	One focus for the coming month	

One rule	What will you repeat?	

20

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER $10K?

The first $10,000 is a milestone. The system should not disappear the day you reach it.

THE GOAL

Turn a balance into a foundation for your next financial decision.

FROM TARGET TO FOUNDATION

Once you reach a meaningful cash milestone, decide what the money is for before choosing what to do next.

Possible goals include strengthening an emergency reserve, preparing for a major purchase, reducing expensive debt, funding education or a business, or building longer-term assets.

The appropriate next step depends on circumstances, jurisdiction, tax rules, risk tolerance, time horizon, and existing obligations.

This workbook intentionally does not prescribe individual stocks, crypto assets, or financial products.

WALTER'S RULE

A larger balance gives you more choices. It does not remove the need for a plan.

YOUR NEXT MONEY CHAPTER

Write what the $10K milestone is meant to enable.

Purpose	What is the money for?	
Protection	What must remain untouched?	
Next milestone	What comes after $10K?	
Time horizon	When will you need it?	
Questions to research	What do you still need to learn?	
Review date	When will you revisit the plan?	

A

THE TOOLKIT

Reusable pages for the system you keep after the first read.

THE GOAL

Print them, duplicate them digitally, and keep using them.

INCOME TRACKER

Record recurring and irregular income.

Income source #1	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #2	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #3	Amount / date / recurring?	

Income source #4	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #5	Amount / date / recurring?	
Monthly total	Total take-home	

BILL CALENDAR

List bills by due date.

Bill #1	Due date / amount	
Bill #2	Due date / amount	
Bill #3	Due date / amount	
Bill #4	Due date / amount	
Bill #5	Due date / amount	
Bill #6	Due date / amount	
Bill #7	Due date / amount	
Bill #8	Due date / amount	

SUBSCRIPTION AUDIT

Every recurring service must earn its place.

Service #1	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #2	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #3	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #4	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #5	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #6	Cost / last used / decision	

SAVINGS PROGRESS

Track milestones.

Starting balance	Date + amount	
Milestone 1	Date + amount	
Milestone 2	Date + amount	
Milestone 3	Date + amount	
Milestone 4	Date + amount	
Current balance	Date + amount	

DEBT PROGRESS

Track balances over time.

Debt #1	Starting → current	
Debt #2	Starting → current	
Debt #3	Starting → current	
Debt #4	Starting → current	
Debt #5	Starting → current	
Total debt	Starting → current	

WEEK 1 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 1 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 2 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 2 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	

Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 3 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 3 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 4 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 4 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 5 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus

- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 5 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 6 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 6 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 7 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 7 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	

Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 8 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 8 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 9 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 9 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 10 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 10 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 11 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 11 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 12 — 90-DAY RESET

15-minute weekly review. Check the system, make one adjustment, and move forward.

- [ ] Check balances and spending
- [ ] Check bills before the next payday
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus
- [ ] Identify one leak or spending trigger
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress

WEEK 12 — NOTES

Keep the answers short.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

B

THE 90-DAY FINAL REVIEW

Do not judge the system only by the final balance. Measure whether your financial behavior and visibility changed.

THE GOAL

Compare Day 1 with Day 90, then decide what survives.

COMPARE DAY 1 → DAY 90

Fill both sides using your original snapshot and current numbers.

Monthly income	Day 1 → Day 90	
Monthly spending	Day 1 → Day 90	
Monthly surplus	Day 1 → Day 90	
Savings	Day 1 → Day 90	
Debt	Day 1 → Day 90	
Savings rate	Day 1 → Day 90	

WHAT STAYS AFTER DAY 90?

Keep the habits that actually worked.

- [ ] Weekly money check.
- [ ] Monthly money reset.
- [ ] Payday system.
- [ ] Automatic savings transfer.
- [ ] Subscription review.
- [ ] Debt payoff routine.
- [ ] 24-hour purchase pause.
- [ ] Savings milestone tracking.
- [ ] Monthly surplus experiment.

YOUR NEXT 90 DAYS

Choose one financial priority. Keep the weekly check. Keep the monthly reset. Increase the surplus when you can. Protect the progress you already made.

The goal was never to become perfect with money. It was to become deliberate with money.

WALTER'S RULE

Build the system. Let the system build the result.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

This workbook's structure was developed around practical financial-management themes found in consumer and financial-education resources, including budgeting, spending tracking, debt planning, savings, cash-flow management, and financial routines.

Useful reference resources include the U.S. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's *Your Money, Your Goals* toolkit, Consumer.gov's budgeting guidance, and the FDIC's Money Smart for Adults curriculum.

These references are included for further education. The workbook does not reproduce their materials or substitute for professional advice tailored to a specific person's circumstances.

FROM YOUR WEALTHY UNCLE

THE NEXT GOOD DECISION

You do not need to know exactly where you will be five years from now. You need to know what your money is doing this week.

Then make the next good decision again next week.

YOUR MONTHLY BUDGET

Make every dollar—or every unit of income—accounted for.

Expected take-home	Income you expect	
Essential spending	Minimum practical cost	
Debt minimums	Required payments	
Savings target	Chosen sustainable amount	
Flexible spending	Planned discretionary amount	
Buffer	Room for timing surprises	

IRREGULAR EXPENSES BELONG IN THE PLAN

Car maintenance, annual subscriptions, gifts, repairs, school costs, travel, and other non-monthly expenses can wreck a budget when they are treated as surprises.

Create a list of known irregular expenses and estimate their annual cost. Divide the annual amount by 12 to understand the monthly planning burden.

You do not need a perfect estimate. You need a visible one.

WALTER'S RULE

A predictable expense is not an emergency just because it happens infrequently.

05

FIND YOUR ESSENTIAL SPENDING FLOOR

Your essential floor tells you what life costs before extras.

THE GOAL

Know the minimum practical cost of keeping your household functioning.

WHAT BELONGS IN THE FLOOR?

Think in terms of expenses you would protect during a financial shock: housing, basic utilities, basic food, necessary transportation, required care or insurance, and minimum debt obligations.

The definition is personal. A commuter may need transportation. A remote worker may not. A parent may have childcare that is essential to employment.

The floor is useful because it tells you what must be protected first.

ESSENTIAL SPENDING FLOOR

List only expenses you would protect in a financial emergency.

Housing	Minimum housing cost	
Utilities / communication	Necessary utilities	
Food	Basic groceries / meals	
Transportation	Necessary commuting	
Health / care	Necessary recurring care	
Debt minimums	Required minimums	
Other essentials	Necessary household obligations	

NORMAL VS. ESSENTIAL

NORMAL	ESSENTIAL	GAP
monthly cost	monthly floor	flexible layer

Write down your normal monthly spending and your essential floor. The difference is your flexible lifestyle layer.

Flexible does not mean bad. It means adjustable. Knowing the difference gives you options when income or expenses change.

06

THE PAYDAY SYSTEM

The day you get paid should trigger a sequence—not a shopping spree.

THE GOAL

Give your income jobs before your lifestyle absorbs it.

THE PAYDAY ORDER

1. Receive. Confirm the actual amount available.

2. Protect. Cover essential bills and required payments.

3. Transfer. Move the planned savings amount.

4. Allocate. Set the amount available for flexible spending.

5. Buffer. Leave room for timing surprises when possible.

WALTER'S RULE

Save by design, not by hoping there is money left at the end.

PAYDAY PLAN

Complete this before or on every payday.

Income received	Amount actually available	
Bills before next payday	Critical obligations	
Savings transfer	Planned transfer	
Debt extra	Beyond minimums, if applicable	
Spending allowance	Flexible spending	
Operating buffer	Unassigned cash for timing	

THE PAYDAY FAILURE TEST

If you repeatedly transfer money to savings and then move it back because essentials cannot be covered, the system is giving you feedback.

Lower the transfer temporarily, fix the cash-flow timing, or increase the surplus. A useful system should reduce financial stress, not create a cycle of false progress.

WALTER'S RULE

The right savings target is one you can protect.

07

BUILD AN EMERGENCY BUFFER

Cash reserves create breathing room. Build them progressively instead of waiting for a perfect number.

THE GOAL

Create layers of resilience that match your circumstances.

THREE STAGES

01	02	03
starter	one month	larger reserve

Stage 1 — Starter buffer: a small accessible cushion for common surprises.

Stage 2 — One month of essentials: a useful milestone for people who can reach it.

Stage 3 — Larger reserve: a target based on income stability, household responsibilities, and personal risk.

These are planning stages, not universal prescriptions.

EMERGENCY BUFFER PLAN

Choose the next milestone rather than chasing a perfect number.

Starter buffer target	First cash cushion	
Essential monthly floor	From Chapter 5	
One-month target	Essential monthly cost	
Current emergency savings	Accessible reserve	
Next milestone	Next amount to reach	
Review date	When you will reassess	

PROTECT THE PURPOSE

Emergency money exists to reduce the chance that a surprise forces you into expensive debt or a destructive financial decision.

Keep it accessible enough for genuine emergencies and separated enough from everyday spending that it is not treated as ordinary cash.

The right account or product depends on your country and circumstances. Compare access, fees, safety, and applicable protections.

08

DEBT WITHOUT THE SHAME

Debt is a set of numbers and obligations. You need a plan, not self-punishment.

THE GOAL

Turn a vague problem into a sequence of decisions.

BUILD THE INVENTORY

For every debt, record the lender, balance, interest rate if known, minimum payment, due date, and current status.

Then choose a payoff order while continuing required payments on every account.

Snowball: prioritize the smallest balance first.

Avalanche: prioritize the highest interest rate first.

The approaches use different priorities. Your job is to understand the trade-off and choose deliberately.

DEBT INVENTORY

One line per debt.

Debt #1	Balance / rate / minimum / due date	
Debt #2	Balance / rate / minimum / due date	
Debt #3	Balance / rate / minimum / due date	
Debt #4	Balance / rate / minimum / due date	
Debt #5	Balance / rate / minimum / due date	
Debt #6	Balance / rate / minimum / due date	

YOUR PAYOFF ORDER

Write the exact order you intend to follow.

Method	Snowball or avalanche	
Target #1	First account	
Target #2	Second account	
Target #3	Third account	
Target #4	Fourth account	
Extra-money rule	How windfalls / reductions will be handled	

09

CREDIT CARDS WITHOUT GETTING TRAPPED

A credit card is a payment tool. The danger appears when the repayment plan becomes unclear.

THE GOAL

Know the statement, the minimum, the due date, and the cost of carrying a balance.

THE FOUR NUMBERS

Statement balance: what the statement says you owe for that cycle.

Minimum payment: the required amount to keep the account current under the issuer's terms.

Due date: when the required payment is due.

Interest terms: the cost of carrying balances under the card agreement.

Terms vary by issuer and country. Read your actual statement.

WALTER'S RULE

Available credit is not income.

CREDIT CARD CHECK

Review every card you use.

- [ ] I know my statement closing date.
- [ ] I know my payment due date.
- [ ] I know the minimum payment.
- [ ] I know whether I am carrying a balance.
- [ ] I know the applicable interest terms.
- [ ] I have a repayment plan for current purchases.
- [ ] I do not count available credit as income.

10

LIFESTYLE INFLATION

More income can improve your life—or simply create a more expensive version of the same financial stress.

THE GOAL

Give new income a job before your lifestyle gives it one.

THE RAISE TRAP

Imagine take-home income rises from $3,000 to $3,500. The extra $500 is not automatically spending money. It is an opportunity to change your financial position.

The trap is subtle: a better phone, more delivery, another subscription, a nicer car, more nights out. Each decision can look reasonable by itself.

Six months later, you can earn more than ever and still feel like there is nothing left.

The solution is not to reject every upgrade. It is to decide deliberately.

WALTER'S RULE

Give every raise a job before you give it a lifestyle.

YOUR RAISE RULE

Write your personal rule before the next increase arrives.

Expected increase	Amount or percentage	
Savings allocation	Amount or percentage	
Debt allocation	Amount toward payoff	
Lifestyle allocation	Intentional upgrade	
Rule	One sentence you will follow	
Review date	When you will check the result	

11

IMPULSE SPENDING

The goal is not to eliminate spontaneity. It is to stop automatic decisions from becoming recurring problems.

THE GOAL

Create a pause between wanting and buying.

THE 24-HOUR PAUSE

Choose a purchase threshold that fits your income. For non-essential purchases above it, create a pause.

During the pause, ask: Do I still want it? Is it in the plan? What problem does it solve? Would I buy it tomorrow? What else could this money do?

The pause does not forbid the purchase. It makes the decision conscious.

WALTER'S RULE

If the purchase still makes sense tomorrow, you can decide tomorrow.

YOUR IMPULSE TRIGGER MAP

Map the pattern, not just the purchase.

Trigger	When does spending happen?	
Feeling	What are you feeling before it?	

Default action	What do you usually buy?	
New response	What will you do for 10 minutes instead?	
Threshold	At what amount will you pause?	
Reminder	Where will you place the reminder?	

12

SPENDING TRIGGERS

Social pressure, stress, boredom, convenience, and celebration can all change behavior.

THE GOAL

Design defaults so good decisions require less effort.

DESIGN A BETTER DEFAULT

Remove saved cards from high-spending apps. Turn off promotional notifications. Set a weekly discretionary amount before the weekend. Create a shopping list before non-essential shopping.

Build convenient low-cost alternatives for recurring expensive habits. The best default is the one you can actually follow when tired.

WALTER'S RULE

Make the desired behavior easier and the undesired behavior slightly harder.

YOUR DEFAULTS

Choose five changes for this week.

- [ ] Remove one saved payment method.
- [ ] Set one weekly discretionary spending limit.
- [ ] Create a shopping list before non-essential shopping.
- [ ] Turn off one promotional notification.
- [ ] Choose one low-cost social activity you genuinely enjoy.
- [ ] Create one convenient alternative to an expensive recurring purchase.
- [ ] Put your next savings milestone where you will see it before spending.

13

YOUR SAVINGS RATE

A savings rate is a measurement, not a moral score.

THE GOAL

Measure the trend so you can tell whether the system is changing.

THE FORMULA

10%	$340	$3.4K
example rate	saved	take-home

Savings rate = amount saved ÷ take-home income.

Example: $340 saved from $3,400 take-home income = 10%.

Do not force a universal target onto your situation. Start with a rate you can repeat. Increase it when the surplus grows.

WALTER'S RULE

A smaller target you repeat beats a bigger target you abandon.

SIX-MONTH SAVINGS RATE TRACKER

Record income, savings, and the resulting rate.

Month 1	Income / saved / rate	
Month 2	Income / saved / rate	
Month 3	Income / saved / rate	
Month 4	Income / saved / rate	
Month 5	Income / saved / rate	
Month 6	Income / saved / rate	

14

BUILD YOUR $10K ROADMAP

Turn the destination into milestones that can survive an ordinary month.

THE GOAL

Give the goal intermediate numbers so progress becomes visible.

MILESTONES

A $10,000 goal can feel abstract. Use checkpoints such as $500, $1,000, $2,500, $5,000, $7,500, and $10,000—or create milestones that fit your starting point.

Each milestone should answer three questions: **How much? By when? What behavior creates it?**

If debt or emergency savings needs attention first, some milestones can be shared between stability and the long-term goal.

$10K ROADMAP

Create a route you can explain in one minute.

Starting balance	Current savings	
Milestone 1	Amount + target date	
Milestone 2	Amount + target date	
Milestone 3	Amount + target date	
Milestone 4	Amount + target date	
$10K target	Target date if realistic	

THE THREE LEVERS

Spend less: reduce outflow without destroying the parts of life you value.

Earn more: increase income through work, skills, selling, or other legitimate means.

Organize better: prevent timing problems, forgotten bills, and automatic leaks from consuming the surplus.

You do not need one dramatic breakthrough. Multiple small levers can compound.

WALTER'S RULE

Build the surplus from several small levers instead of waiting for one dramatic breakthrough.

15

INCREASE YOUR SURPLUS

Your savings capacity is not fixed. Test both sides of the equation.

THE GOAL

Run a 30-day experiment and measure the result.

THE 30-DAY SURPLUS CHALLENGE

Choose one expense-side experiment and one income-side experiment.

Expense examples: cancel unused subscriptions, change a recurring default, set a weekly discretionary cap, reduce one high-frequency convenience expense.

Income examples: sell unused items, offer a skill-based service, take appropriate extra work, or test a small freelance offer.

The objective is not to build a fantasy business in a month. It is to prove that your monthly surplus can move.

WALTER'S RULE

Measure the experiment, not the fantasy.

30-DAY SURPLUS CHALLENGE

Make the experiments measurable.

Expense experiment	What will you change?	
Expected impact	Monthly amount freed	
Income experiment	What will you test?	
Expected impact	Monthly amount created	
Combined surplus target	New monthly target	
Review date	When you will evaluate	

WEEKLY SURPLUS ACTIONS

Repeat for four weeks.

- [ ] Review one recurring expense.

- [ ] Review one variable category.
- [ ] Complete one income-producing action.
- [ ] Transfer the savings created by the experiment.
- [ ] Record what worked and what did not.
- [ ] Do not add a recurring expense just because income increased.

16

THE 90-DAY RESET

The next 90 days are about installing the system, not performing financial theater.

THE GOAL

Move from clarity to control to building to acceleration.

DAYS 1–7 — CLARITY

Complete the financial snapshot. Map the last 30 days. List every debt. Audit subscriptions. Calculate the essential floor. Choose your budget method.

Do not chase a huge savings target yet. Your job is to make the system visible.

WALTER'S RULE

Do not optimize what you have not measured.

DAYS 8–30 — CONTROL

Run the payday routine. Remove obvious leaks. Establish the starter buffer target. Choose your debt payoff order. Implement your spending-trigger rules.

The goal is fewer uncontrolled money decisions and a positive or improving monthly surplus.

DAYS 31–60 — BUILD

Automate what makes sense. Increase the savings transfer if the first month was sustainable. Run the surplus challenge. Build the next milestone.

Use weekly reviews to adjust the plan instead of abandoning it.

DAYS 61–90 — ACCELERATE

Review your savings rate. Compare current spending with the starting snapshot. Increase the surplus where possible. Set the next 90-day target.

At day 90, the best outcome is a system you can continue without this workbook.

YOUR 90-DAY TARGET

Set realistic numbers you can measure.

Starting savings	Current balance	
90-day savings target	Target amount	
Monthly surplus target	Target surplus	
Debt target	Balance reduction	
Behavior target	One habit to automate	

Review date	Day 90 evaluation	

17

AUTOMATE YOUR MONEY

Automation is useful when it protects a decision you have already made.

THE GOAL

Automate the boring parts without removing your oversight.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

Depending on your bank and cash flow, consider automating recurring bills, a regular savings transfer, and debt payments you know you can cover.

Automation does not remove the need for review. Check balances, upcoming obligations, and transfers regularly.

Leave enough operating cash to prevent overdrafts or failed payments.

AUTOMATION SETUP

Choose only what fits your cash flow.

- [ ] Recurring essential bills are organized.
- [ ] Savings transfer is scheduled.
- [ ] Debt minimum payments are protected.
- [ ] I know when each transfer occurs.
- [ ] I keep enough operating cash for timing differences.
- [ ] I review automated transactions during the weekly check.

18

THE WEEKLY MONEY CHECK

Fifteen minutes once a week can prevent small problems from becoming end-of-month surprises.

THE GOAL

Create a short review that keeps the system alive.

15-MINUTE WEEKLY CHECK

Do this once every seven days.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Check your savings transfer.
- [ ] Check debt balances if you are in payoff mode.
- [ ] Identify one category that is running high.
- [ ] Make one adjustment for the coming week.
- [ ] Update your $10K progress.

WEEKLY CHECK-IN

Keep answers short and practical.

What went well?	One thing to repeat	
What surprised me?	Unexpected spending or income	
Where did I overspend?	Category + amount	
What will I change?	One concrete adjustment	
Savings this week	Amount	
Next week's priority	One action	

19

THE MONTHLY MONEY RESET

Once a month, close the old month and give the next month a job.

THE GOAL

Turn your budget into a feedback loop.

THE 30–45 MINUTE RITUAL

Review income received, total spending, savings, debt payments, subscriptions, and next month's known obligations.

Compare actual spending with the budget. Do not punish yourself for variance; explain it.

Then move money according to your priorities and choose one change for next month.

WALTER'S RULE

Your budget becomes more accurate because it learns from reality.

MONTHLY RESET

Complete at the end or beginning of each month.

- [ ] Record total take-home income.
- [ ] Record total spending.
- [ ] Record total saved.
- [ ] Calculate savings rate.
- [ ] Update debt balances.
- [ ] Review subscriptions.
- [ ] Review upcoming irregular expenses.
- [ ] Choose next month's savings target.
- [ ] Choose one expense or income experiment.
- [ ] Update $10K progress.

MONTHLY REVIEW

Close the month with decisions, not guilt.

Biggest win	What improved?	
Biggest leak	What cost more than expected?	
Savings	Amount saved	

Debt	Amount reduced	
Next priority	One focus for the coming month	
One rule	What will you repeat?	

20

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER $10K?

The first $10,000 is a milestone. The system should not disappear the day you reach it.

THE GOAL

Turn a balance into a foundation for your next financial decision.

FROM TARGET TO FOUNDATION

Once you reach a meaningful cash milestone, decide what the money is for before choosing what to do next.

Possible goals include strengthening an emergency reserve, preparing for a major purchase, reducing expensive debt, funding education or a business, or building longer-term assets.

The appropriate next step depends on circumstances, jurisdiction, tax rules, risk tolerance, time horizon, and existing obligations.

This workbook intentionally does not prescribe individual stocks, crypto assets, or financial products.

WALTER'S RULE

A larger balance gives you more choices. It does not remove the need for a plan.

YOUR NEXT MONEY CHAPTER

Write what the $10K milestone is meant to enable.

Purpose	What is the money for?	
Protection	What must remain untouched?	
Next milestone	What comes after $10K?	
Time horizon	When will you need it?	
Questions to research	What do you still need to learn?	
Review date	When will you revisit the plan?	

A

THE TOOLKIT

Reusable pages for the system you keep after the first read.

THE GOAL

Print them, duplicate them digitally, and keep using them.

INCOME TRACKER

Record recurring and irregular income.

Income source #1	Amount / date / recurring?	

Income source #2	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #3	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #4	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #5	Amount / date / recurring?	
Monthly total	Total take-home	

BILL CALENDAR

List bills by due date.

Bill #1	Due date / amount	
Bill #2	Due date / amount	
Bill #3	Due date / amount	
Bill #4	Due date / amount	
Bill #5	Due date / amount	
Bill #6	Due date / amount	
Bill #7	Due date / amount	
Bill #8	Due date / amount	

SUBSCRIPTION AUDIT

Every recurring service must earn its place.

Service #1	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #2	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #3	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #4	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #5	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #6	Cost / last used / decision	

SAVINGS PROGRESS

Track milestones.

Starting balance	Date + amount	
Milestone 1	Date + amount	
Milestone 2	Date + amount	
Milestone 3	Date + amount	

Milestone 4	Date + amount	
Current balance	Date + amount	

DEBT PROGRESS

Track balances over time.

Debt #1	Starting → current	
Debt #2	Starting → current	
Debt #3	Starting → current	
Debt #4	Starting → current	
Debt #5	Starting → current	
Total debt	Starting → current	

WEEK 1 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 1 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 2 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 2 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 3 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 3 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 4 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 4 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	

Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 5 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 5 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 6 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 6 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 7 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 7 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 8 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 8 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 9 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.

- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 9 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 10 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 10 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 11 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 11 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 12 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 12 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

B

THE 90-DAY FINAL REVIEW

Do not judge the system only by the final balance. Measure whether your financial behavior and visibility changed.

THE GOAL

Compare Day 1 with Day 90, then decide what survives.

COMPARE DAY 1 → DAY 90

Fill both sides using your original snapshot and current numbers.

Monthly income	Day 1 → Day 90	
Monthly spending	Day 1 → Day 90	
Monthly surplus	Day 1 → Day 90	
Savings	Day 1 → Day 90	
Debt	Day 1 → Day 90	
Savings rate	Day 1 → Day 90	

WHAT STAYS AFTER DAY 90?

Keep the habits that actually worked.

- [ ] Weekly money check.
- [ ] Monthly money reset.
- [ ] Payday system.
- [ ] Automatic savings transfer.
- [ ] Subscription review.
- [ ] Debt payoff routine.
- [ ] 24-hour purchase pause.
- [ ] Savings milestone tracking.
- [ ] Monthly surplus experiment.

YOUR NEXT 90 DAYS

Choose one financial priority. Keep the weekly check. Keep the monthly reset. Increase the surplus when you can. Protect the progress you already made.

The goal was never to become perfect with money. It was to become deliberate with money.

WALTER'S RULE

Build the system. Let the system build the result.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

The practical structure of this workbook draws on established financial-education themes such as spending tracking, cash-flow budgeting, debt planning, savings, emergency reserves, and repeatable financial routines.

For further reading, see the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's *Your Money, Your Goals* toolkit, Consumer.gov's budgeting guidance, and the FDIC's Money Smart for Adults curriculum.

These resources are provided for further education. This workbook does not reproduce their materials and is not a substitute for advice tailored to a specific person's circumstances.

FROM YOUR WEALTHY UNCLE

THE NEXT GOOD DECISION

You do not need to know exactly where you will be five years from now.

You need to know what your money is doing this week.

Then make the next good decision again next week.

YOUR PAYOFF ORDER

Write the exact order you intend to follow.

Method	Snowball or avalanche	
Target #1	First account	
Target #2	Second account	
Target #3	Third account	
Target #4	Fourth account	
Extra-money rule	How windfalls / reductions will be handled	

09

CREDIT CARDS WITHOUT GETTING TRAPPED

A credit card is a payment tool. The danger appears when the repayment plan becomes unclear.

THE GOAL

Know the statement, the minimum, the due date, and the cost of carrying a balance.

THE FOUR NUMBERS

Statement balance: what the statement says you owe for that cycle.

Minimum payment: the required amount to keep the account current under the issuer's terms.

Due date: when the required payment is due.

Interest terms: the cost of carrying balances under the card agreement.

Terms vary by issuer and country. Read your actual statement.

WALTER'S RULE

Available credit is not income.

CREDIT CARD CHECK

Review every card you use.

- [ ] I know my statement closing date.
- [ ] I know my payment due date.
- [ ] I know the minimum payment.
- [ ] I know whether I am carrying a balance.
- [ ] I know the applicable interest terms.
- [ ] I have a repayment plan for current purchases.
- [ ] I do not count available credit as income.

10

LIFESTYLE INFLATION

More income can improve your life—or simply create a more expensive version of the same financial stress.

THE GOAL

Give new income a job before your lifestyle gives it one.

THE RAISE TRAP

Imagine take-home income rises from $3,000 to $3,500. The extra $500 is not automatically spending money. It is an opportunity to change your financial position.

The trap is subtle: a better phone, more delivery, another subscription, a nicer car, more nights out. Each decision can look reasonable by itself.

Six months later, you can earn more than ever and still feel like there is nothing left.

The solution is not to reject every upgrade. It is to decide deliberately.

WALTER'S RULE

Give every raise a job before you give it a lifestyle.

YOUR RAISE RULE

Write your personal rule before the next increase arrives.

Expected increase	Amount or percentage	
Savings allocation	Amount or percentage	
Debt allocation	Amount toward payoff	
Lifestyle allocation	Intentional upgrade	
Rule	One sentence you will follow	
Review date	When you will check the result	

11

IMPULSE SPENDING

The goal is not to eliminate spontaneity. It is to stop automatic decisions from becoming recurring problems.

THE GOAL

Create a pause between wanting and buying.

THE 24-HOUR PAUSE

Choose a purchase threshold that fits your income. For non-essential purchases above it, create a pause.

During the pause, ask: Do I still want it? Is it in the plan? What problem does it solve? Would I buy it tomorrow? What else could this money do?

The pause does not forbid the purchase. It makes the decision conscious.

WALTER'S RULE

If the purchase still makes sense tomorrow, you can decide tomorrow.

YOUR IMPULSE TRIGGER MAP

Map the pattern, not just the purchase.

Trigger	When does spending happen?	
Feeling	What are you feeling before it?	
Default action	What do you usually buy?	
New response	What will you do for 10 minutes instead?	
Threshold	At what amount will you pause?	
Reminder	Where will you place the reminder?	

12

SPENDING TRIGGERS

Social pressure, stress, boredom, convenience, and celebration can all change behavior.

THE GOAL

Design defaults so good decisions require less effort.

DESIGN A BETTER DEFAULT

Remove saved cards from high-spending apps. Turn off promotional notifications. Set a weekly discretionary amount before the weekend. Create a shopping list before non-essential shopping.

Build convenient low-cost alternatives for recurring expensive habits. The best default is the one you can actually follow when tired.

WALTER'S RULE

Make the desired behavior easier and the undesired behavior slightly harder.

YOUR DEFAULTS

Choose five changes for this week.

- [ ] Remove one saved payment method.
- [ ] Set one weekly discretionary spending limit.
- [ ] Create a shopping list before non-essential shopping.
- [ ] Turn off one promotional notification.
- [ ] Choose one low-cost social activity you genuinely enjoy.
- [ ] Create one convenient alternative to an expensive recurring purchase.
- [ ] Put your next savings milestone where you will see it before spending.

13

YOUR SAVINGS RATE

A savings rate is a measurement, not a moral score.

THE GOAL

Measure the trend so you can tell whether the system is changing.

THE FORMULA

10%	$340	$3.4K
example rate	saved	take-home

Savings rate = amount saved ÷ take-home income.

Example: $340 saved from $3,400 take-home income = 10%.

Do not force a universal target onto your situation. Start with a rate you can repeat. Increase it when the surplus grows.

WALTER'S RULE

A smaller target you repeat beats a bigger target you abandon.

SIX-MONTH SAVINGS RATE TRACKER

Record income, savings, and the resulting rate.

Month 1	Income / saved / rate	
Month 2	Income / saved / rate	
Month 3	Income / saved / rate	
Month 4	Income / saved / rate	
Month 5	Income / saved / rate	
Month 6	Income / saved / rate	

14

BUILD YOUR $10K ROADMAP

Turn the destination into milestones that can survive an ordinary month.

THE GOAL

Give the goal intermediate numbers so progress becomes visible.

MILESTONES

A $10,000 goal can feel abstract. Use checkpoints such as $500, $1,000, $2,500, $5,000, $7,500, and $10,000—or create milestones that fit your starting point.

Each milestone should answer three questions: **How much? By when? What behavior creates it?**

If debt or emergency savings needs attention first, some milestones can be shared between stability and the long-term goal.

$10K ROADMAP

Create a route you can explain in one minute.

Starting balance	Current savings	
Milestone 1	Amount + target date	
Milestone 2	Amount + target date	
Milestone 3	Amount + target date	
Milestone 4	Amount + target date	
$10K target	Target date if realistic	

THE THREE LEVERS

Spend less: reduce outflow without destroying the parts of life you value.

Earn more: increase income through work, skills, selling, or other legitimate means.

Organize better: prevent timing problems, forgotten bills, and automatic leaks from consuming the surplus.

You do not need one dramatic breakthrough. Multiple small levers can compound.

WALTER'S RULE

Build the surplus from several small levers instead of waiting for one dramatic breakthrough.

15

INCREASE YOUR SURPLUS

Your savings capacity is not fixed. Test both sides of the equation.

THE GOAL

Run a 30-day experiment and measure the result.

THE 30-DAY SURPLUS CHALLENGE

Choose one expense-side experiment and one income-side experiment.

Expense examples: cancel unused subscriptions, change a recurring default, set a weekly discretionary cap, reduce one high-frequency convenience expense.

Income examples: sell unused items, offer a skill-based service, take appropriate extra work, or test a small freelance offer.

The objective is not to build a fantasy business in a month. It is to prove that your monthly surplus can move.

WALTER'S RULE

Measure the experiment, not the fantasy.

30-DAY SURPLUS CHALLENGE

Make the experiments measurable.

Expense experiment	What will you change?	
Expected impact	Monthly amount freed	
Income experiment	What will you test?	
Expected impact	Monthly amount created	
Combined surplus target	New monthly target	
Review date	When you will evaluate	

WEEKLY SURPLUS ACTIONS

Repeat for four weeks.

- [ ] Review one recurring expense.
- [ ] Review one variable category.
- [ ] Complete one income-producing action.
- [ ] Transfer the savings created by the experiment.
- [ ] Record what worked and what did not.
- [ ] Do not add a recurring expense just because income increased.

16

THE 90-DAY RESET

The next 90 days are about installing the system, not performing financial theater.

THE GOAL

Move from clarity to control to building to acceleration.

DAYS 1–7 — CLARITY

Complete the financial snapshot. Map the last 30 days. List every debt. Audit subscriptions. Calculate the essential floor. Choose your budget method.

Do not chase a huge savings target yet. Your job is to make the system visible.

WALTER'S RULE

Do not optimize what you have not measured.

DAYS 8–30 — CONTROL

Run the payday routine. Remove obvious leaks. Establish the starter buffer target. Choose your debt payoff order. Implement your spending-trigger rules.

The goal is fewer uncontrolled money decisions and a positive or improving monthly surplus.

DAYS 31–60 — BUILD

Automate what makes sense. Increase the savings transfer if the first month was sustainable. Run the surplus challenge. Build the next milestone.

Use weekly reviews to adjust the plan instead of abandoning it.

DAYS 61–90 — ACCELERATE

Review your savings rate. Compare current spending with the starting snapshot. Increase the surplus where possible. Set the next 90-day target.

At day 90, the best outcome is a system you can continue without this workbook.

YOUR 90-DAY TARGET

Set realistic numbers you can measure.

Starting savings	Current balance	
90-day savings target	Target amount	
Monthly surplus target	Target surplus	
Debt target	Balance reduction	
Behavior target	One habit to automate	
Review date	Day 90 evaluation	

17

AUTOMATE YOUR MONEY

Automation is useful when it protects a decision you have already made.

THE GOAL

Automate the boring parts without removing your oversight.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

Depending on your bank and cash flow, consider automating recurring bills, a regular savings transfer, and debt payments you know you can cover.

Automation does not remove the need for review. Check balances, upcoming obligations, and transfers regularly.

Leave enough operating cash to prevent overdrafts or failed payments.

AUTOMATION SETUP

Choose only what fits your cash flow.

- [ ] Recurring essential bills are organized.
- [ ] Savings transfer is scheduled.
- [ ] Debt minimum payments are protected.
- [ ] I know when each transfer occurs.
- [ ] I keep enough operating cash for timing differences.
- [ ] I review automated transactions during the weekly check.

18

THE WEEKLY MONEY CHECK

Fifteen minutes once a week can prevent small problems from becoming end-of-month surprises.

THE GOAL

Create a short review that keeps the system alive.

15-MINUTE WEEKLY CHECK

Do this once every seven days.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Check your savings transfer.
- [ ] Check debt balances if you are in payoff mode.
- [ ] Identify one category that is running high.
- [ ] Make one adjustment for the coming week.
- [ ] Update your $10K progress.

WEEKLY CHECK-IN

Keep answers short and practical.

What went well?	One thing to repeat	
What surprised me?	Unexpected spending or income	
Where did I overspend?	Category + amount	
What will I change?	One concrete adjustment	
Savings this week	Amount	
Next week's priority	One action	

19

THE MONTHLY MONEY RESET

Once a month, close the old month and give the next month a job.

THE GOAL

Turn your budget into a feedback loop.

THE 30–45 MINUTE RITUAL

Review income received, total spending, savings, debt payments, subscriptions, and next month's known obligations.

Compare actual spending with the budget. Do not punish yourself for variance; explain it.

Then move money according to your priorities and choose one change for next month.

WALTER'S RULE

Your budget becomes more accurate because it learns from reality.

MONTHLY RESET

Complete at the end or beginning of each month.

- [ ] Record total take-home income.
- [ ] Record total spending.
- [ ] Record total saved.
- [ ] Calculate savings rate.
- [ ] Update debt balances.
- [ ] Review subscriptions.
- [ ] Review upcoming irregular expenses.
- [ ] Choose next month's savings target.
- [ ] Choose one expense or income experiment.
- [ ] Update $10K progress.

MONTHLY REVIEW

Close the month with decisions, not guilt.

Biggest win	What improved?	
Biggest leak	What cost more than expected?	
Savings	Amount saved	
Debt	Amount reduced	
Next priority	One focus for the coming month	
One rule	What will you repeat?	

20

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER $10K?

The first $10,000 is a milestone. The system should not disappear the day you reach it.

THE GOAL

Turn a balance into a foundation for your next financial decision.

FROM TARGET TO FOUNDATION

Once you reach a meaningful cash milestone, decide what the money is for before choosing what to do next.

Possible goals include strengthening an emergency reserve, preparing for a major purchase, reducing expensive debt, funding education or a business, or building longer-term assets.

The appropriate next step depends on circumstances, jurisdiction, tax rules, risk tolerance, time horizon, and existing obligations.

This workbook intentionally does not prescribe individual stocks, crypto assets, or financial products.

WALTER'S RULE

A larger balance gives you more choices. It does not remove the need for a plan.

YOUR NEXT MONEY CHAPTER

Write what the $10K milestone is meant to enable.

Purpose	What is the money for?	
Protection	What must remain untouched?	
Next milestone	What comes after $10K?	
Time horizon	When will you need it?	
Questions to research	What do you still need to learn?	
Review date	When will you revisit the plan?	

A

THE TOOLKIT

Reusable pages for the system you keep after the first read.

THE GOAL

Print them, duplicate them digitally, and keep using them.

INCOME TRACKER

Record recurring and irregular income.

Income source #1	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #2	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #3	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #4	Amount / date / recurring?	
Income source #5	Amount / date / recurring?	
Monthly total	Total take-home	

BILL CALENDAR

List bills by due date.

Bill #1	Due date / amount	
Bill #2	Due date / amount	
Bill #3	Due date / amount	
Bill #4	Due date / amount	
Bill #5	Due date / amount	
Bill #6	Due date / amount	
Bill #7	Due date / amount	
Bill #8	Due date / amount	

SUBSCRIPTION AUDIT

Every recurring service must earn its place.

Service #1	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #2	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #3	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #4	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #5	Cost / last used / decision	
Service #6	Cost / last used / decision	

SAVINGS PROGRESS

Track milestones.

Starting balance	Date + amount	
Milestone 1	Date + amount	
Milestone 2	Date + amount	
Milestone 3	Date + amount	
Milestone 4	Date + amount	
Current balance	Date + amount	

DEBT PROGRESS

Track balances over time.

Debt #1	Starting → current	
Debt #2	Starting → current	
Debt #3	Starting → current	
Debt #4	Starting → current	
Debt #5	Starting → current	
Total debt	Starting → current	

WEEK 1 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.

- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 1 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 2 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 2 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 3 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 3 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 4 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 4 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 5 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 5 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 6 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 6 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 7 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 7 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 8 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.

- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 8 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 9 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 9 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 10 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 10 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 11 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 11 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	
Next action	One action for the next seven days	

WEEK 12 — 90-DAY RESET

One page, one weekly review.

- [ ] Check current account balances.
- [ ] Review the last seven days of spending.
- [ ] Check bills due before the next payday.
- [ ] Complete the planned savings transfer.
- [ ] Take one action that increases surplus.
- [ ] Identify one spending trigger or leak.
- [ ] Update debt and/or savings progress.

WEEK 12 — NOTES

Record the decision that matters most this week.

Win	What worked?	
Problem	What needs attention?	
Money moved	Savings / debt / other	

Next action	One action for the next seven days	

B

THE 90-DAY FINAL REVIEW

Do not judge the system only by the final balance. Measure whether your financial behavior and visibility changed.

THE GOAL

Compare Day 1 with Day 90, then decide what survives.

COMPARE DAY 1 → DAY 90

Fill both sides using your original snapshot and current numbers.

Monthly income	Day 1 → Day 90	
Monthly spending	Day 1 → Day 90	
Monthly surplus	Day 1 → Day 90	
Savings	Day 1 → Day 90	
Debt	Day 1 → Day 90	
Savings rate	Day 1 → Day 90	

WHAT STAYS AFTER DAY 90?

Keep the habits that actually worked.

- [ ] Weekly money check.
- [ ] Monthly money reset.
- [ ] Payday system.
- [ ] Automatic savings transfer.
- [ ] Subscription review.
- [ ] Debt payoff routine.
- [ ] 24-hour purchase pause.
- [ ] Savings milestone tracking.
- [ ] Monthly surplus experiment.

YOUR NEXT 90 DAYS

Choose one financial priority. Keep the weekly check. Keep the monthly reset. Increase the surplus when you can. Protect the progress you already made.

The goal was never to become perfect with money. It was to become deliberate with money.

WALTER'S RULE

Build the system. Let the system build the result.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

The practical structure of this workbook draws on established financial-education themes such as spending tracking, cash-flow budgeting, debt planning, savings, emergency reserves, and repeatable financial routines.

For further reading, see the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's *Your Money, Your Goals* toolkit, Consumer.gov's budgeting guidance, and the FDIC's Money Smart for Adults curriculum.

These resources are provided for further education. This workbook does not reproduce their materials and is not a substitute for advice tailored to a specific person's circumstances.

THE NEXT GOOD DECISION

You do not need to know exactly where you will be five years from now.

You need to know what your money is doing this week.

Then make the next good decision again next week.